

Presentism Trial Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	presentism-trial

Big idea: Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

Overview

Students explore ethical judgement and contextual understanding in history.

Student Prompt

Inspect Presentism Trial Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Presentism Trial Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Presentism Trial Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Presentism Trial Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Presentism Trial Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Presentism Trial Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Should we judge the past by present standards?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how historical judgement involves ethical tension.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards.
- Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge.
- A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Put the historical case "on trial".	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Half the class uses present-day values. Half uses values and constraints of the period.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	The judge panel decides what each side understood and ignored.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Debrief the difference between explanation, justification and excuse.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Broken Archive
- Same Event, Different Historian
- Cause Web